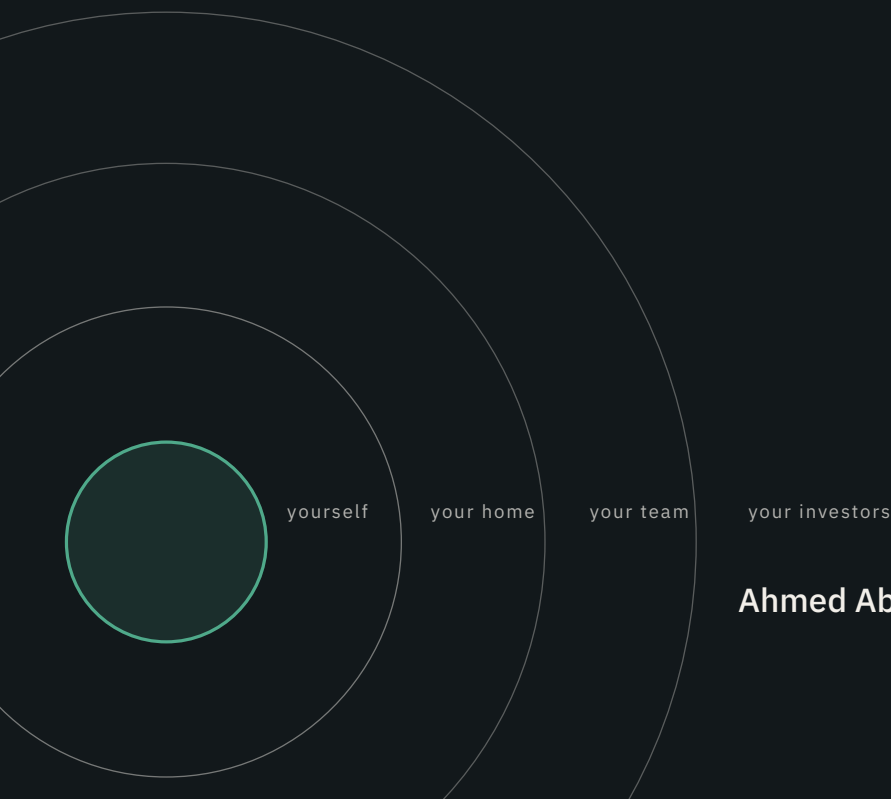


THE STRUCTURE OF A FOUNDER IN THE AGE OF AI

A Wider Life for Founders

You are building your company
and tearing yourself down



Ahmed Abuelhaz

2026

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Before you start

How to enter this book

You do not have to read this in order. Work out where you are, and come in through your own door.

Working, choking, and short of time

Start at chapter 13, page **94**, then 14. One act in three doses and a week you can repeat. When you have done it two weeks running, come back to the beginning to find out why it worked.

In the middle of a crisis right now

Chapter 15, page **105**. A down round, a pivot, a co-founder crisis. Read that today and leave the rest.

You want to understand why it got narrow

From the first page, in order. Part one is a diagnosis and not a charge, and part two is the map.

You want a sheet in your hand today

The practical part, page **121**. One page that gets filled in, and two weeks already filled in by hand.

The whole book on one page

If you only read one page

The shape is fixed, and one thing inside it changes.

- 01 Pick **one circle** of the four: yourself, your home, your team, your investors. One, not two.
- 02 Pick **one act** inside it, small enough that you could say it out loud to your co-founder without flinching.
- 03 Give it **three doses**: full, half, smallest. The same act at three sizes, not three acts to choose from.
- 04 **Hang it on something that happens anyway**: after standup, when the last call ends, on the drive home.
- 05 Name a **sign you can see**, something you can answer yes or no to. Otherwise it is talk.
- 06 At the end of each day write one of two words: **done** or **smaller**. There is no third box and **no box for failure**. And one day a week you unplug by rule, not by mood.

THE SHAPE OF THE WEEK

Circle yourself · your home · your team · your investors

Act one thing, in three doses

Hook what the act hangs on

Sign what you will see if you moved

Seven boxes done or smaller · and one open day

Full sheet the practical part, page **121**

The promise

This is a book for someone who left a job to be free and found the narrowest cage a person can walk into.

Nothing struck him. The company did not close, the team did not walk out, the product works and customers pay for it. People look at him and say: good for you, you are your own boss now.

And he is the only one who knows the truth.

He knows he left one manager who held him from nine until five and bought himself fifty managers instead. Every customer is a manager, every investor is a manager, and every engineer on the team is waiting for him to solve everything. He knows his bed now has a laptop in it and notifications that never settle, and that he counts the months left in the runway the way a prisoner counts what is left of a sentence.

And the heaviest part of it is that he knows. **That is the real problem: he is not ignorant.**

He has read the famous business books. He knows what product market fit means, the whole scaling vocabulary, the podcasts with founders who exited for millions. Then he wakes and half his attention

is spent before he has washed his face. He opens the dashboard with his chest tight, and the day goes by one fire at a time, and none of them builds anything for tomorrow.

He gets home with a tiredness that has left no mark on his body. He sits with his partner and children in the same room and not a quarter of him is with them; his head is in the investor email nobody answered, the good engineer he is sure is about to resign, the server that could go down at any minute.

And once or twice a month, when it gets heavy enough, he opens his notes at night and writes a new plan for his life: wake at five, the gym, no Slack after eight, the weekend for his family. He holds it two days. Then an investor asks for a call at no notice, and it falls the way it fell the last twenty times. And one more line goes into him: **I am not cut out to be a founder.**

The problem is not that you are not cut out to be a founder.

The problem is that nobody ever taught you a structure that protects you while you build.

You are not short of one more piece of information about growth, or another book on getting an investor to yes in twenty minutes, or a talk telling you to love your work or leave it. **You are short of structure.**

Short of something that tells you: you are here now, the thing happening in your chest is not weakness and not failure, it is called this, it is treated by this, and your next step is exactly this. And when the cash

pulls against your home, or an investor's approval pulls against your own honesty, this one comes first.

That is what this book is. One map: what you are made of as a founder, what narrows your life while you run after growth, what widens it, and how to walk through a real week with a runway falling, a team waiting to be paid, and a home that needs a person and not a machine.

How to read it

Read it in order the first time, because the four parts are built on each other like the floors of a building.

Part One says why it got narrow, and that is a diagnosis, not a charge: what turned founding into a trap, and why your fear is not a defect in your will. **Part Two** is the map: the six layers under every founder, the difference between a cash crisis that passes and a terror that has moved in, and the twenty two things that take founders down. **Part Three** is the four circles: yourself, your home, your team, the authority under your hand, and your investors and your board, the authority above you. **Part Four** is the heaviest in weight and the lightest to read: how to walk through a day, a week and a year, and what to do when a down round lands and you are standing still.

And at the end of every chapter there is one act in three doses. **Take the dose you know you can do tonight, in the conditions your**

company is actually in, not the dose you would like to look capable of.

And what this book is not

It is not a magic plan that makes you a unicorn in a year, and it is not a promise that you will stop being tired. Founding is heavy and it will stay heavy.

But there is a wide difference between a tiredness that opens your chest, that you sleep after and wake up settled, and a narrowing that takes your breath and makes you hate the day you started a company.

The aim is not that the tiredness disappears. The aim is that your life becomes wide enough for what is in it.

And if what is on you is heavier than this, if the fear has kept you from sleeping for months, if the debt and the responsibility have frozen your thinking, then this book on its own is not enough. There is nothing shameful in looking for someone who does this well, for your head or for your finances, and it is no failure in your courage.

So if you are ready, close every tab in front of you for a minute and sit here with me.

01

PART ONE

Why it got narrow

A diagnosis, not a charge. What is happening in your chest, and why it is not a skill you are missing.

-
- 01 A founder who knows everything and does not move
 - 02 Your company did not choke you overnight
 - 03 Burnout is not bankruptcy, it is dust settling
 - 04 Who are you building for?

A founder who knows everything and does not move

In two lines

There is no missing piece of information between you and a company that works and a life that is wide. What is between you and it is **an order of operations**.

This chapter shows you why every book on founding and scaling you have read has not landed in your day, and why that is not a weakness in your will.

One of us

Take a founder.

He wakes fifteen minutes after the alarm he set last night. The first thing his hand finds is the phone: forty Slack messages, an alert that a server went down before dawn, and a line from his lead investor asking how the numbers look this week.

He opens the laptop with half his nervous energy already spent and gives nine hours to the screen: an anxious customer, the good engineer he is trying to keep, the burn closed out for the month.

In the afternoon he takes the ten minutes he keeps for his daughter, and he is with her with the same tab open in his head.

At night he shuts the laptop wrecked. Ask what he moved in the core of the business today and he goes quiet. Twenty small fires, and no brick laid for tomorrow.

At the weekend he opens LinkedIn in bed: a competitor has raised three million dollars. Something tightens in his throat. What are they doing that I cannot do.

At the start of the month he writes enormous goals in a new file: 100K MRR, a new seed round, the sales cycle rebuilt. Three days later a sales crisis arrives and he is back in the spiral, with one settled feeling: the fault is in me, I cannot run this.

The real problem is not that he cannot run it.

The problem is that he has never been given a method built for an actual human being, with energy that runs out and nerves that fray.

Knowing and being able

Sit with him and ask about his metrics and he will give you an analysis sharper than the best consultant you could hire. He knows his CAC

and his LTV and his churn, he knows micromanagement is wrong, he knows short sleep wrecks his decisions.

Then say to him: good, **what will you do tomorrow at nine?** You will find him stalling.

Because the distance between knowing the theory and putting it into a real day is not crossed with one more article. That distance has a name, and the name is **order**: what gets done today, what gets dropped even if the whole ecosystem says it matters, and what size of work you can actually carry.

So every time the pressure rises he buys another course. **He does not need books. He needs one smallest real step, held for three weeks.**

Frameworks, no compass

There are two doors in front of this founder, and both reach the same wall.

The first door is the modern business books. They are excellent at indexing: numbered steps, boards, a KPI for every second. But they deal with you as a machine with no household behind it, and they treat your fear the way a fault in an engine gets treated. **They have the process and not the stillness.**

The second door is the talk about wanting less. Someone tells you to let go, that money is dust on the hands, that the ambition itself

is the illness. You come out of it flattened, because you have cheques to clear this month and people with households waiting on salaries.

The damage is the same in both: **nothing holds honest effort and clean dealing together with a heart that is not owned by what other people decide about you.**

And why in your time

The merchant did not carry this alone.

There was an hour in the middle of his day when the whole street stopped at once, so he never had to decide when to stop. Before even-
ing he turned the key and went home. **The work had an edge it ended at.** No customer reached him at ten at night, and no investor asked for a report at the weekend.

And he had peers who knew his fault and would say it to his face, not competitors performing on a feed while they burn the way you burn.

Then in one generation the door came off. Work became the life, the company moved into the phone, and the phone came under the blanket with you. **So you build for yourself what used to be built around a man without him noticing.** That is not a shortage of will. It is a shortage of structure.

And the narrowing has a name

Take the definition exactly:

Narrowing is not bankruptcy, and it is not a bad quarter, and it is not bad luck. It is that everything is present and the space is small.

Your company may be valued at twenty million dollars, people clapping at conferences, and your chest narrower than the eye of a needle.

It is what happens when a founder's connection to the meaning is cut: when the investor is what sits in your heart, the runway is where your safety comes from, and the valuation is the measure of your worth. The money stays, and the space that holds you shrinks until you cannot breathe in it.

And if narrowing is the illness, width is the cure. That is why this book is called what it is called. Not a promise that the business gets easy: a promise that your life widens for what is in it.

The smallest place to start

One line for a founder lost between a hundred priorities:

The measure is not the size of the act. The measure is that it lasts.

The measure in building a company, and in building yourself, is not the heat that starts on Sunday and collapses on Wednesday. It is the small act you can repeat tomorrow without it costing you everything.

That line strikes out most of your lists, and raises the value of the smallest correct decision you make every day.

THE ACTION

One act, one night. Choose a fixed moment in your day: the first time you open the laptop, or the minute your first meeting ends.

DOSE	THE ACT
Full	At that moment write three lines: where exactly your company got narrow today, on which screen, and with whom, an investor, a customer, or someone on the team
Half	One line only: where did it get narrow today
Smallest	One word for what you are afraid of tonight: cash, investor, sales, team

The sign that you moved: after three days you find yourself writing the same word. What repeats three times is not annoyance at one email, **it is the actual thread, and it is now in your hand.**

And do not write down why you failed to hold it yesterday. There is no box for self punishment in this book, and there will not be one.

Your company did not choke you overnight

In two lines

What is happening in your chest today happened to a whole generation of founders, and it did not happen because you are weaker than the people who made it before you. **Four things used to carry the merchant and went in one generation, and three things arrived and choked the field.**

This chapter gives you the account, not so you sit down under it, but so you stop fighting an enemy you think is in your chest when it is in the ground you stand on.

Four things carried the merchant

Your grandfather with a shop was not stronger in will than you. He was carried by an order that protected him from himself and from the market.

A door that closed. His work had an edge: a wooden door he shut at the end of the day, a key turned in the lock, and that was that. No customer reached into his house at ten at night. Your company has no

door. The product runs all night, support arrives at any minute, and the work follows you into bed with the phone buzzing under the pillow.

A local ceiling. He measured his success against his own street and his own town. If the household was covered and the stock was moving, he slept content. You measure yourself against the planet: you open the screen and the feed hands you twenty three year olds in San Francisco raising hundreds of millions. **So the ceiling of your contentment hangs on a comparison with numbers that are not normal.**

The safety of real economics. He worked on a simple law: buy for a pound, sell for a pound and a quarter. Earn the quarter and he lived; lose it and he knew he was sinking, so he closed. There was no game called burn the cash now and work out later how to make it. Venture capital turned that over. **It made you live on the next injection instead of on what your hands earn,** and locked you in the terror of a runway that shortens every morning.

The old man in the market. There was a man forty years ahead of him who had seen the slump and the boom. If he saw the young trader reaching for stock he could not carry, he would tell him to slow down, this one will break your back. And he listened. You have no old man in the market. You have advisors by the hour, taking a percentage or a fee, and none of them is carrying what you carry. If your company shuts tomorrow, none of them loses anything.

Four things carried the merchant, and they went in one generation. **They did not go because you sent them away, and nobody asked you.**

And three things arrived

The first: runway terror. Your investor is not a lender taking his interest. He is a partner in your kitchen with a say in the decisions that decide your life. And cash stopped being safety and became a countdown to the death of the company. Six months of runway left: that sentence turns a healthy man into a bundle of pulled wires. Under it you sacrifice your conscience and your sleep and your home, **because your mind believes that if the company dies you die with it.**

The second: an industry of performance. A liar used to be found out in two weeks. Now there is a whole business built on polishing companies and inflating numbers. You watch valuations thrown around at conferences and you are the only one who knows three quarters of it is air. Seeing it every day leaves you permanently late, as though everyone woke up except you. **And when envy gets into a founder he makes mad hires and buys losing campaigns, so that he looks large.**

The third: machines and an inhuman speed. A commercial idea used to take years to copy. Today the product you spent a year building can be rebuilt by a small team in two weeks, or one model update can wipe out half the value you sell. That is not only competition. It is a

pressure that has moved in and makes the ground feel unsteady every night.

An easy start has a price

And there is a fourth, and it arrives dressed as a gift.

Starting anything used to cost real effort: the running around, the paperwork, months of waiting before the first coin came in. That effort built a muscle for waiting. Today you register a company with a click and ship to the world in two days. **The ease abolished the patience.** So a founder who has not raised or sold in six months decides he has failed, and breaks at the first obstacle the merchant would have walked past.

And one line names the race:

*Piling up is not building, and distraction is not prevention.
Nobody prevented you.*

What gets piled up here is headcount as a false pride, and valuation, and rounds, and features. **Distraction is being occupied with those until it is over and the company is closed, and if you were asked why, you would have no honest answer.**

An explanation, not an excuse

This has to be said plainly, or the chapter becomes a hook to hang your disappointment on.

Knowing the field is mined and the load heavier is a diagnosis, so you understand what is happening in you. **It is not a licence to sit in a corner and say the market is cruel and the investors are unfair.**

The gain is that you now know where your enemy is:

- It is not a shortage of intelligence in you.
- It is not that you are not equal to the responsibility.
- It is an environment mined with screens, false comparisons, a Slack with no rules, and notifications that take your quiet.

And that is good news: what is in your chest takes years to change, while what is in your room and your phone and your policy with your team changes in five minutes.

And you are not asked to carry what cannot be carried:

What cannot be lifted was never asked of you.

The race the funds want you in is not compulsory. **Nobody appointed you to be a unicorn in three years except your own picture of yourself.**

THE ACTION

Change one thing in your surroundings and not in your will: something physical, that closes a door your attention leaks through.

DOSE	THE ACT
Full	Delete LinkedIn and Slack from your phone for three days, and deal with both from the work laptop only, at hours you set
Half	Turn off LinkedIn notifications completely, and the notifications on every public Slack channel, leaving direct messages and critical alerts
Smallest	Log out of LinkedIn on your phone tonight

The sign that you moved: your hand goes to the phone before sleep to see who raised a round, and the app is not there. You notice, put it down, and come back to what is in front of you. **That is a part of your stolen attention coming home.**

Burnout is not bankruptcy, it is dust settling

In two lines

This is the chapter that explains why you are collapsing inside a company that has not collapsed, and why you cannot say when the collapse began.

Founder burnout does not arrive as one explosion. It arrives as small particles you let pass every day until they cover the glass: the argument with your co-founder you keep postponing, the firing you have delayed three months, the number you dressed up in the investor update.

Not a courtroom

A warning for the founder with a live conscience. The point of seeing the dust is not to sit every night as a prosecutor and come out heavy and unable to work. **Treat yourself the way a good doctor treats a wound, to clean it and close it, not the way a judge passes sentence.**

And a stumble in business that leaves you needing other people is better for you than a fast success that leaves you above them.

And sometimes it is just weight, and no one is to blame.

Mirror and dust

Picture a clean mirror in a new room. It shows your face without any effort, because that is its nature.

Now leave the window open on a public street for a month. No brick is thrown, no hammer touches it. Every hour one particle lands, too small for the eye.

After a month your reflection is dulled, and you rub your eye and assume your sight has gone.

That is exactly how burnout happens to a founder. You start with a clean intent and real energy. Two years later you wake unable to get out of bed, open the laptop with something like nausea, and say: I am burnt out, I am not fit for this.

You did not burn, and your judgement is not broken. A thick layer of small daily dust has settled on the glass, and every particle was something you called normal at the time.

Nothing fell on you from the sky. It gathered, one day at a time, and every particle was yours.

Small and repeated

This is the opposite of what the crisis management books tell you, and the reason is simple.

The large crisis hurts. An investor pulls his offer and the runway drops to two months, or a customer worth half your revenue leaves. That pain is a shock that wakes you: you get the team in a room, call the emergency, rebuild the plan. **The pain itself produces movement,** which is why companies come out of real disasters stronger.

The small does not hurt. It passes quietly, no alarm rings, so no pause is called, so it repeats. Then your mind gets used to it, and then you defend it and call it being commercial:

- A number lifted a little in the deck: not a flat lie, just optimism, so the valuation keeps moving.
- A conversation with your co-founder you keep putting off, because the split is wrong or the workload is, and you swallow it out of fear of the friction, and the silence turns into bitterness.
- Someone on the team you know is poisoning the room, and you delay because there is no time to hire, and every day he stays takes from the team's respect for you.
- A supplier's payment held three weeks with his money in your account, to protect the cash a little, and you sleep with that man's waiting around your neck.
- A message to the team on a Saturday: not urgent, just your anxiety emptied into their chest, taking their day with their families.

Not one of them brings the company down. **Together they are enough to blur your sight, so that you take blind strategic decisions believing you are thinking clearly.**

The most dangerous thing in your company is not the competitor outside. **It is the small practice you do every day and do not count as a thing.**

Dust hides, it does not replace

The mirror under the dust is a mirror. It has not turned to stone.

This is the part to hear today, because it stops despair. A founder who reaches burnout starts passing final sentences on himself: I turned out to be a fraud selling a dream, I am not fit to lead. **That is confusing broken with covered.**

If it is broken, throw it away and leave founding. If it is covered, what is needed is a cloth. Your wish to succeed honestly, and your care for the living of the people with you, are still there, buried under fear and the games of the market. **The difference between seeing yourself as finished and seeing yourself as needing a wipe is the difference between giving up and getting up.**

Every dust its own cloth

Dust does not lift with talk or with reading about ethics. It lifts with a real act of the opposite kind.

If the dust is dressing up the numbers, its opposite is not private regret. It is sitting in the next investor meeting and saying plainly: this number slipped this month, and here is what we are doing about it. That clears the glass and gives you back your standing.

If the dust is avoiding the confrontation, its opposite is half an hour of coffee tomorrow morning with your partner, where everything gets said and nothing is left in your chest.

If the dust is helping yourself to your team's life, its opposite is telling them plainly: no Slack after seven, no work at the weekend, and being the first to keep it.

The medicine is always a concrete act. **It stings at first, then it opens a space in your chest and in your company you did not think was there.**

Three questions for a decision

This is the tool for anything you are unsure about. Take the practice that is bothering you and ask three questions, no more:

THE QUESTION	WHAT YOU ARE LOOKING FOR
What does it darken in me?	The truth I have stopped wanting to see
Which right decision does it block?	The straight step I would have taken if I were not afraid
What is its opposite today?	One small act tomorrow morning that turns it

Try them on the file you have been postponing for a month. **The third is the only one that moves you from paralysis to work.**

THE ACTION

Choose one small practice you do every week that you consider normal and know is not straight.

DOSE	THE ACT
Full	Do its opposite tomorrow morning: send the honest email with nothing dressed up, or fix a time for the conversation you have been avoiding with your partner, or pay what you owe
Half	Write the situation on paper with complete honesty, and under it the right decision, with no circling
Smallest	The moment you catch yourself doing it tomorrow, name it silently: this is dust, not sharpness

The sign that you moved: the moment you used to slip past, the confrontation avoided or the truth dressed up, starts being visible while you are inside it, and your tongue hesitates before it says the thing. **That hesitation is the start of your compass coming back.**

Who are you building for?

In two lines

One act in business is not one thing. Two founders give the same pitch, in front of the same investors, and one comes out of the day wider and calmer while the other comes out narrower and emptied.

The difference is not the skill and not the idea. **It is what moved him.** This chapter turns intent into a tool that protects you, not a line you admire.

Two in the same incubator

Take two founders who started in the same incubator, the same fourteen hour days, the same market.

The first works with his eye on his image in the ecosystem. He rewrites the investor email seven times, not to make the idea clearer but so he will not look weak. He goes to every conference for the photograph, and when news about him lands on LinkedIn the hunger grows; when an investor ignores a message, something in him panics.

He is genuinely tired, and he goes home empty, **because the one working all day was not him, it was a mask built for the taste of the funds.**

The second does the same work, is tired the same way, and negotiates hard on his valuation. But the company is not proof that he is a genius. It is a trust, a living, a responsibility. He builds the product to fix a real customer's pain, and he is fair with the households behind his payroll.

So when an investor turns him down he is upset for half an hour like anyone, then goes back to his customer with a clear head, because this fund is not where his living comes from. He gets home with something left over for his family, **because his worth is not held hostage to an investor's approval.**

The effort is the same, the numbers are the same, the result in the life completely different.

An act runs on what moved you, not on what you said in the pitch.

Not a mission statement

Most founders think intent is the sentence on the About page, that we are here to change the world. That is public relations.

Real intent is the honest engine that pushed you out of bed this morning, the bare answer to: why am I actually opening this company.

You may say that you do this to solve people's problems, while what is moving you is terror that people will call you a failure if you close, or a hunger to prove your family wrong.

Intent is not known by good words. It is known by its trace:

- If your work on the product loses its heat when the conferences stop, you have learned what was driving it.
- If you handle a small customer with contempt and fly when a famous name asks for you, you have learned who you are building for.

The chain before a decision

Look at how a decision happens in you. Five links passing in seconds: a **thought** crosses, then a **leaning**, then a **resolve**, then an **intention** sets, then **the decision** is executed.

You hear of a funding wave in some technology. The thought crosses: look what investors are paying there. If it stopped there it would be nothing; thoughts cross everybody. Then something leans: why not put the word in our pitch even if we do not do it. Then the resolve: competitors do it and we are not less. Then the intention sets: change the roadmap and catch the trend. Then the team loses two months and the company's focus is gone.

The wise founder stops at the second link, at the leaning toward imitation, and asks: does this help a real customer, or is it theatre for investors?

The place to fight is not the last link. A founder arguing at the fifth, with the roadmap already rewritten, fights in the narrowest spot. **The skill is to move the fight earlier.**

Motives gather

There is another mistake, and the founder with a live conscience is the one who makes it: he looks for one perfectly clean motive, cannot find it, decides he is a hypocrite, and either drops the work or freezes.

Motives gather. They do not arrive one at a time. You wake with four at once: you want to earn honestly and secure your household, you like the challenge, you enjoy it when people value your work, and you want to build something useful where you live. That is the ordinary condition of a healthy person, not proof of rot.

The right question is not whether your intent is free of any wish for praise. **It is: which one of these would have been enough on its own?**

If the press went quiet and the large investor said no, but there is still a customer who needs the service and a team at work, would you carry on? If yes, you are sound, even with some love of being seen mixed in. If you would drop the product tomorrow because only the show mattered, **then you have found where the illness is, without demolishing your company.**

A limit not to cross

The red line: do not turn this into an anxious court that stops the work.

Motives hide and change colour: a man can believe one thing moved him when another did. Anyone who wants certainty that no vanity is in an email he sends will freeze and produce nothing, **and that paralysis costs an honest founder more than the vanity ever did.**

Keep it as a sorting question when things are unclear, not a scale for every line you write. **You have no authority to pass a final sentence on yourself, and neither does anyone else.**

Why this widens a life

What chokes you is not the number of hours. **It is working day and night to satisfy people you are not convinced by.**

A full day of pressure and hard negotiation, if it has a direction you are at peace with, passes heavy but does not pass narrow. You sleep after it with your dignity, riding the tiredness instead of under it.

The direction does not change the market or remove the competition. **It changes what you take from every step.**

So this book will not ask you to leave your company or stop wanting a large success. It asks something cheaper: know exactly who you are doing this for.

THE ACTION

Choose one decision you will take tomorrow: a hire, a feature, an email to your investors.

DOSE	THE ACT
Full	Before you take it, ask honestly: if nobody in the ecosystem would ever know about this, and no praise would come from it, would I still do it? Write the answer in one line, then decide
Half	Ask the question silently and hold the answer for one minute, without writing
Smallest	Before you press send or sign, say one word for the real purpose: trust, show, fear, work

The sign that you moved: mid week you stop a decision, or a feature you were going to ship, not because the cash was short, **but because when you asked honestly there was nothing behind it but the wish to be seen.** That braking is where a founder grows up.

02

PART TWO

The map

What you are made of as a founder, what chokes the company and the man running it, and what the opposite of it is.

-
- 05 Six layers under the founder
 - 06 A cash crisis passes, the fear moves in
 - 07 The twenty two, in startup language
 - 08 Every ailment is treated by its opposite

Six layers under the founder

In two lines

You are not a title on a cap table, and you are not the list of leadership traits the management books hand out.

You are six layers stacked on each other, and most of what you try fails because you treat a layer with the layer above it: you sit down to fix the ten year strategy on four hours of sleep, two weeks running. This chapter gives you the order, and the law of movement between the layers.

Why layers and not traits

Open any well known book on leadership and it counts out the traits a successful founder is supposed to have: negotiates well, holds up under shocks, thinks strategically, delegates, emotionally intelligent. That is a pleasant list on a stage and useless at eleven at night with three months of runway left, because it never tells you who is carrying whom.

Layers tell you that plainly. What is underneath carries what is above, so if what is underneath has cracked you cannot repair what is

above, however hard you push. A founder fixing how he leads his team while his body is wrecked is painting the third floor while the foundations open under him.

The six layers

Zero · your body. Your sleep, your food, how much you move, how many hours your eyes spend on lit screens. This is the layer hustle culture taught you to despise as an obstacle, and it is the one that brings most founders down. The founder who slept four hours, ran the day on coffee, and then made a hiring decision at four in the afternoon that he will spend a year undoing does not need a course in emotional intelligence. **The body is the first gate every decision of yours passes through, not a servant that carries your head to meetings.**

1 · what you do. What the team and the investors actually see of you: your messages on Slack, how you speak in a meeting, the promises you keep and the ones you let slide, how you treat the most junior person on the team when he gets something wrong. The fastest layer to change and the least stable with no steady body under it.

2 · your state. What is passing over you today: tight or open, high after a promising investor email, shut down after a large customer cancels. **This layer is moving by nature, so nothing is built on it.** The worst mistake a founder makes is to build a decision that cannot be reversed on a state that will be gone by Thursday: cutting half the team on one narrow night, or signing an expensive office two days after a round closes.

3 • what sits inside you. What is settled in you and repeats and does not leave when the situation leaves: the fear of the cash running out that follows you into every hour, the attachment to what investors think of you, the discomfort when a competitor raises, the buried wish to prove you were right and they were wrong. This layer is the real field, and the next two chapters take it.

4 • what you think it is all for. Your silent answer to the question nobody at work will ask you: why did you open this company at all? Is the trade an honest pursuit that serves people, or the only means you have of proving you are a person of worth? **A founder whose answer here is damaged can raise millions and reach a large exit and still find a hollowness he cannot name.**

5 • that it ends. That this game finishes, and that something of you stays after it. That the last measure is not the valuation and not the number in the account: it is whether the money was clean and whether you dealt fairly with the people under your hand. If this layer is missing, every reckoning is short, because the only scale left is the next eighteen months, and a bad quarter reads as a sentence on your whole life.

And a plain line about the last two layers: this book does not give you an answer to what it is all for, or to what comes after. What it says is that both questions exist, and a founder living as though there were no question is paying a price without knowing what he pays it for.

Three laws of movement

Three laws, and they save you a shelf of management books.

The first: a layer is repaired by the one beneath it, not the one above it. A founder who wants to repair how he runs his team, layer one, starts from his sleep, layer zero, not from a new operating cadence he writes on Sunday. And a founder who wants the cash terror to leave him, layer three, will not get there by talking himself into a better mood. He goes down to layer four, to what he thinks the money is for.

The second: what is above builds what is below, slowly. Repeated conduct sinks after months into what sits inside you. Hold your temper when you are afraid, deal straight when you could win by not dealing straight, and the practice turns fear into something steadier. **As dust settles by repetition, it lifts by repetition.**

The third: do not diagnose one layer in the language of another. The commonest way founders flog themselves is to give a body problem the name of a character defect. You wake unable to think about the sales strategy and say: I have gone soft, I am not the size of my ambition. In fact you slept three hours and are running a strategy offsite on an empty tank.

Where you start today

One rule, and there is no other: **start from the lowest layer that has something wrong with it.**

This is a repair order for a founder already standing, not a list to clear before you begin. If you are still starting, start, and fix as you go.

If your sleep is a wreck, you have no business in this book tonight except closing the laptop and sleeping eight hours. If your body is steady and your day is scattered, start from the day and the meetings. Do not climb to the ten year vision while the foundations shake.

This is the hardest thing in the book on a founder, because the self loves to talk about grand strategy and thinks it beneath itself to fix a bedtime. Whoever starts building from the roof has built in the air.

THE ACTION

DOSE	THE ACT
Full	Draw the six layers on a blank sheet and write one word next to each: sound, or unsettled. Underline the first unsettled one from the bottom, and make it your target for the next two weeks
Half	Look at the first two only, your body and what you do, and decide which of them has fallen further
Smallest	Answer one question honestly: how many hours a night did you sleep this week, on average?

The sign that you moved: you stop taking decisions that cannot be reversed on the days when layer zero is down, and hold them until you have slept. **That braking means you are running the company with your mind and not with burnt nerves.**

A cash crisis passes, the fear moves in

In two lines

Before you walk into the map of the next chapter, you need to tell the difference cleanly: a storm in the market that passes over you, and a fear that has moved in and lives with you.

A founder who treats a passing cash crisis as a permanent verdict on his character has tortured himself and stalled his company for nothing.

A hard week is no verdict

You wake into a week where every door is shut in your face.

The investor who promised you a term sheet withdraws at the last minute in a cold email. Your CTO walks into your office without warning and says he has an offer abroad and cannot continue. The payment gateway goes down for two days in the heaviest selling season of the year.

So you sit at your desk at night with the office dark and you say to yourself: I am a failure, I am not built for this, the company is finished.

And perhaps you are not a failure and the company is not finished. Perhaps this is one of the ordinary storm weeks that pass over the largest companies. **A startup is a living thing that catches colds and has growth crises like any child**, and this crisis has passed over people with far more experience than you, and over companies worth billions today.

How to tell them apart

Three practical distinctions are enough, and you need no philosophy with them.

WHAT YOU COMPARE	A STORM PASSING OVER	SOMETHING SETTLED IN YOU
How long	Days, or a few weeks	Months and years
Relation to its cause	Goes quiet the moment the material cause is solved	Stays in your chest after the cause has been solved and paid off
Where it shows	In one place: the sales dashboard, one meeting	In every circle: your bed, your marriage, the ten minutes you have with your daughter, your holiday

Look hard at the second one, because that is the scale that settles it.

If the fear in you is tied to the cash in the bank running out in two months, and a large deal closes or a wire lands and you settle, that was a

thing passing over you. A liquidity crisis, treated by good operating, cut spending and two weeks of patience.

But if a million dollars lands in the company account and you still wake up every morning terrified, chest tight, unable to stand your own team, certain you are a fraud who will be exposed tomorrow, **then this is not cash. This is a fear that has moved into you and taken a room.** It will not be solved by a new round or an exit, because you will carry it into every company you build after this one.

Why the distinction matters this much

For two reasons, and both are life or death for the company.

The first is that the treatment is completely different. A passing storm in a business is carried, not treated with theories. What it mostly needs is enough sleep, clean food, silence instead of the impulsive message, one calm meeting with the team to move the work around, and days passing quietly. A thing that has settled in you, the fraud feeling, the standing suspicion of everybody, the terror of failing, is treated by its opposite over months. **A founder who treats a passing market storm as a chronic illness wears himself out analysing while the company sinks.** And a founder who treats a resident fear with quick painkillers, a new round, or hiding inside the work night and day, thinks he is better while he is building a bomb with a clock on it.

The second is that self flogging starts here. The founder who calls every dip in sales a personal failure, and every stumble with an in-

vestor an insult to his dignity, spends his nights in a court where he is the judge, the accused and the man who carries out the sentence. And that flogging on its own eats eighty per cent of the mental energy that was supposed to go into the product and into the real problems.

This book does not diagnose you

Here is a part that has to be completely plain between us.

What is written here is not a certified diagnosis of your company, and it cannot be. If a business adviser treated every company that came to him with the same prescription he would wreck most of them. You know your data, your market and your team better than any page you are reading, and the page cannot see your bank statement or hear the argument you had with your co-founder.

So take from this map what you are sure describes you, and leave what feels far from you. Everything you match against yourself here is a supposition you review quietly, not a verdict you bring down on your own head.

And then there is a limit where we stop completely. **If the tightness and the fear have been with you for long months, and have taken your sleep and your appetite, and are keeping you from working and thinking, and you no longer want anything at all, this is not the door of this book on its own.** Look now for someone who does this professionally where you live, and do not count it as weakness in you or a shortage of will. Nobody blames anyone for find-

ing medicine for high blood pressure, and exhaustion under the pressure of building is the same.

THE ACTION

Take the heaviest thing on your mind in the company this week and put it through the three distinctions above.

DOSE	THE ACT
Full	Write the problem in one line, and answer the three underneath it: how long has it been here, would money genuinely settle it, and is it touching your home and your sleep or staying inside the laptop
Half	Answer one question honestly: does this follow you to your bed and your house, or does it stay shut inside the laptop?
Smallest	Write today's date on a sheet, the name of the problem, and one word beside it: storm, or resident. Look at the sheet in two weeks

The sign that you moved: a hard week passes over you, sales down or an investor saying no, and you build no verdict on yourself out of it. You take one breath and say to your team and to yourself: this is a storm and we will cross it. **That sentence alone widens your chest and saves more of your energy than you expect.**

The twenty two, in startup language

In two lines

This is the map of what narrows your chest and chokes your company. Twenty two, in six large families, **and it is not a list of management faults and not a charge sheet.**

These are descriptions of things settled in a founder that eat at his space and his clarity while he calls them good business sense. You will find no definitions here. In each one you will find how to see it in your day, and the act that lifts it.

Three limits before you read the list

The first: you will not find yourself in twenty two. You will find yourself in three or four at most, and among them one will be the mother and the rest branches growing out of her. What is asked of you here is not to repair them all. **It is to choose one.**

The second: do not read looking for the ugliest thing in you. Read looking for the thing that repeats most in your week. This book

works on the repeated and not on the rare, because the repeated is what lays the dust, as the mirror chapter set out.

The third: this is a supposition you review, not a verdict you sign. You may read a description and take it for yourself when it is not you, and you may pass quickly over the one that is you because you have lived with it until it became your management style. So stay calm, and pass no final sentence on yourself. **And this is a mirror for yourself only. The moment you use it on anyone else, you have broken it.**

Family one · When the compass dims

This is the quietest of the families and the most dangerous, because there is no sharp pain in it to raise an alarm. Nothing in it catches fire. Everything in the company thins and dies slowly.

1 · The days pass and you build nothing (lost in ops)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

You reach the night unable to say what you finished in the core of the business. Fifty messages, five calls, two meetings, and not one brick laid in the product or in real selling

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Two hours every morning with nothing on the laptop but code or the sales file, Slack and WhatsApp shut

2 · Nothing reaches you any more (founder numbness)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

A large customer walks and you finish your coffee cold. You sign a big investment and feel nothing. No grief, no gladness, no fear, as if the feeling had been anaesthetised

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Sit with your smallest customer face to face and listen to him. Then thank one good engineer by name, and mean it

3 · The cold after the round or the launch (the deadly flatness)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

You closed the round or shipped the new version on a wild high, and two weeks later the air is out of the tyre. The work stands, orderly, with no life in it

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Lower the dose and do not stop. This is a passing state, so carry it until the energy comes back

4 · There is still cash, it is early on the runway (putting it off)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

You defer the hard decisions and defer building the sales machine because there are eight months in the bank, so you buy subscriptions and hire people you do not need

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Do the runway maths as though it were four months, and write the cash plan as though no investor will ever wire again. **And if your runway is under six months, this rule is not for you now: a decision like that is not taken while you are terrified**

The first of this family is its mother: being lost in the operating day. Whoever gets two hours back for the core of the business finds the other three lighten with it.

Family two · When the same mistake circles

5 · I will come back to it next quarter (putting off the firing)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

You know this person is wrong for the role and is spoiling the team, and every time you decide, then defer, then give one more chance, and three months later it is the same scene

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

One conversation, complete fairness in what he is owed, no deferral

6 · The screens pull harder than I do (forced distraction)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

You close the laptop to think about strategy, and the thought comes: let me look at the analytics. You open the screen and sink an hour into numbers that change nothing

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Change place at once. Out of the office with paper and a pencil and no device on you

7 · The market is like this and we can do nothing (management despair)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

You have stopped testing new sales channels, not because you cannot, but because you have already passed sentence on the company and on the market

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Know that despair is weakness, not realism. Produce one very small sales hypothesis and test it tomorrow morning

Family three · When you rise above the market and the team

8 · I am the only one who understands (micromanagement)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

You cannot picture an employee emailing a customer without your review, or an engineer shipping a feature before you approve it line by line. You are choking the team and carrying it all alone

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Delegate one whole task today and do not go near it, even if it goes wrong, and let him fix his own mistake

9 · In love with the product (founder blindness)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

You admire your own code and your own design so much that you turn down feedback from customers and investors, and see people as failing to understand your brilliance

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Sit with a customer who refused to buy and listen for half an hour without defending the product with one word

10 · Hungry for PR and the successful founder image

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

You choose the conferences and the podcasts for your name and your face, and care more about being visible in the tech community than about your numbers being real

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Do something large in the business this week, put no post about it on LinkedIn, and tell nobody

11 · Waiting for growth by magic while nobody sells (the vanity of hope)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

You expect the company to grow suddenly because the idea is brilliant, so you leave the cold calls and the real outreach and say: good things sell themselves

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

The difference is one question: how many customers did you speak to today? Go and call five of them yourself

Family four · When the business rots from inside

12 · Building for the eyes of the VCs (theatre in the building)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

You put features in the product and lines in the plan not because a customer needs them, but because the funds like to hear them in a pitch

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

A decision to kill any feature that exists only for investor display and does nothing for the customer

13 · Inspection that never ends (paralysis by analysis)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

You redraft the deck thirty times and ask for endless data cuts before any decision, until the competitor is past you and the window has closed

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

A decision seventy per cent complete and executed tonight beats a perfect decision that arrives in two months

Family five · When it goes wrong with people

This is the widest of the families and the one that shows most in an ordinary founder's day.

14 · Their round bothers me (founder envy)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

A competitor announces a large raise and there is a bitterness in your throat, and somewhere in you a wish that they hit a wall

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Wish the other founder well quietly, by name, and praise something good they built in front of your team

15 · I blow up at the team and regret it (anger, and taking liberties)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

Your voice rises and your messages go dry and hard at the engineer or the support agent who has nobody to back them. Then you explain: I am under pressure from the investors

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Leave the office or the chat in the same moment, and write no reply at all while angry, for two full hours

16 · I swallow it with my co-founder (the buried grudge)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

Your partner does things that provoke you and you keep quiet because you fear the fight, so the dealings cool and the black stacks up until the partnership breaks

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Ask him for a sitting outside the office within forty eight hours: this bothered me and I want us to fix it together

17 · My tongue gets ahead of me (over promising)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

You promise the customer features nobody has built yet, and promise the investor growth you know your team cannot ship on that date

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Hold to literal truth for one week: promise nothing that is not actually ninety per cent ready

18 · My eye on other people's equity

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

You keep working out other people's cap tables, who holds what, who sold at what price, your heart attached to what sits in the funds' hands

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Count what is in your own hands, one by one, by name, instead of counting what is in theirs

19 · Every investor question is a conspiracy (reading the worst)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

The investor asks about a simple number, or is slow to answer an email, and you build a scenario that he does not trust you and wants you out of the CEO seat

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Read the silence in the best way available: the man is busy. Then prepare your numbers, clear and calm, with no aggression

Family six · When it goes wrong with the company and the cash

20 · My company is my worth (identity attached)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

You cannot picture yourself as a person without the founder title, and you feel that if the company closes your life is over and you are worth nothing

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Write a sheet: I am a father, a husband, a friend, a person with worth even if the company closes tomorrow

21 · I pay the team and it hurts (tight with bonuses and equity)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

The team hits something real, and when you come to hand out a bonus or ESOP you find yourself begrudging it while something in you fights you

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Reward one outstanding person today with something they did not expect, meant as thanks and goodwill

22 · I cannot accept the downturn (raging at the market)

HOW TO SEE IT IN YOUR DAY

The market turns, or your sector goes flat, and you spend day and night cursing the conditions and the country, adding the torment of objection to the weight of the crisis

THE OPPOSITE, AS AN ACT

Accept that this is one of the laws of trade, a day for you and a day against you, and work on it at the same time

Four distinctions that stop a common mistake

WHAT GETS MIXED UP

THE DIFFERENCE, IN ONE QUESTION

I am the only one who understands · and caring about quality

Do you let the one who got it wrong fix it and learn, or pull the task off him and say I will do it faster myself?

The cold after the round · and management despair

Are you still working the basics and still selling with the energy quiet, or have the attempts stopped altogether?

WHAT GETS MIXED UP

THE DIFFERENCE, IN ONE QUESTION

Steadiness about what comes in · and sitting out of the selling

Did you go down and make your calls, or are you sitting in the air conditioning waiting for customers to come to you?

Envy of competitors · and honest competition

Do you wish the deal would slip out of their hands, or do you wish to get past them by your own work and build the like of it and better?

THE ACTION

Choose one of the twenty two. **One, not two.** The one that put a catch in your throat as you read it, the one you knew has been eating at you for a while.

DOSE	THE ACT
Full	Write under it three specific situations that happened in your company last week, and under each one a single act from the opposite column that you will do tomorrow
Half	Write one situation under it that you will act against tomorrow morning
Smallest	Mark one line in the tables above, and write nothing at all today

The sign that you moved: a moment passes in the middle of the week where you are walking straight into it, shouting at an employee, opening the screens compulsively, softening a number for an investor, and you stop for one second and say: this is it, this is exactly it. **Whoever saw the ailment while he was inside it has covered half the road.**

Every ailment is treated by its opposite

In two lines

Half the map you saw in the last chapter is what narrows your chest and chokes your company. **This chapter is its other half: what widens.**

A founder who tries to stop micromanaging by force of will alone has spent himself in a battle he cannot win, because the self does not empty, it gets occupied. The founder who knows the real opposite is at rest, because one spot in a founder's heart will not hold both.

Why stopping is not enough

Try tonight deciding not to think about next month's sales, or the runway, for one minute. You will find your mind holding nothing else.

The self under pressure is like a server: take a service off it and put nothing in its place, and it keeps throwing errors and burning cycles on nothing. The founder who stopped himself shouting at the team and found nowhere to put the anxiety got the anger back in a

worse form: cold messages on Slack, people ignored, a quiet sarcasm that pulls the team down harder than shouting did. The founder who stopped himself opening LinkedIn, and put no deep work in the empty place, opened the app at one in the morning at his weakest hour.

So the rule is: **do not only stop. Put its opposite in the place.**

The opposite is an act

This is the most important practical rule in the chapter.

Much of what gets written about management psychology tells you: to be rid of envy of your competitors, learn to be glad at other people's success. That describes the outcome you hope for and hands it to you as the medicine.

Feelings do not come to order. You are not a machine with a switch to press, Set Jealousy = False, and feel glad for a competitor in a second. **The act is what you can be commanded to do and what you own. The feeling comes after it.**

Which is why in a founder's life the opposite is always something material: done with your hand, your tongue, or your decisions, even while everything in you pulls the other way.

IF WHAT NARROWS YOU AND THE COMPANY IS	THEN ITS OPPOSITE IS AN EXECUTIVE ACT OF THIS KIND
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Envy at a competitor's round	Wishing the founder well quietly, and writing to your team in a public channel: they built something good here and we should learn from it
Obsession with PR and your face at conferences	Turning down one conference or a large podcast this week, and spending those two days reviewing code or answering support tickets from small customers
The need to control everything (micromanagement)	Giving one of your managers a small budget or a whole decision to own, closing your screen, not checking behind him, letting him get it wrong and learn on the company's money
A resident terror of the cash running out	Giving quietly from your own money to someone who will never know it came from you, and paying a bonus to a team member who supports a family, to break the illusion that everything that comes in comes from your hand alone
Quick anger and tension with the team	Getting up from behind the desk the moment you feel the heat, delaying any email by two hours, and walking a quarter of an hour in the street

And what is wanted is not that you find sweetness in the act on the day you do it. What is wanted is that you repeat it. The heart follows the hand and the tongue after a while, exactly as it followed the dust of fear before.

The root everything wide branches from

If you gathered everything that widens a founder's chest and traced it back to one root, it comes back to one thing, said plainly and without decoration: **that there is something you love that is larger than your company and larger than what the market says it is worth.**

A founder whose heart is filled by something larger finds that the things which used to drive him mad have shrunk, not because he fought them, but because they no longer weigh with him what they used to weigh. Sales fell? We did the work and we will fix what broke, and the world has not ended. An investor said no? The money is not locked behind that one door. A competitor got ahead? Nobody eats another man's bread. **That is the difference between a founder resisting his fear while coming apart inside the narrowest cage, and a founder standing on solid ground, at rest, while the company crosses a storm.**

And this book does not tell you what that larger thing is. That answer is yours, from wherever you came by it. What it says is that a founder with nothing larger than himself and his company is trying to lift the whole narrowing with his own two hands, and his hands will not lift it.

The four large ones

From that root four things branch, and they are what let a company grow without grinding you down.

Accepting after you have tried. You take what the market did after you have spent everything you had on the effort and the planning. Acceptance does not come before the trying, it comes after it. A man sitting still doing nothing and saying I accept it is idle, not accepting. The founder who worked, negotiated honestly and then took the result is the one whose back no crisis breaks.

Seeing what you have while you are still in it. Not waiting to lose a thing to learn what it was worth: the honest engineer still beside you, the customer who put his money into your service on trust, the health that still lets you think and lead.

Staying in the right place while it is heavy. Holding to sound fundamentals when the state is bad: a clean product, real sales that earn, and no reaching for the mad burn and the quick hype that goes up in the air.

Doing well the work nobody sees. The infrastructure no engineer will read for years, the contracts that protect your employees' rights, paying people what they are owed on the day it is due. **Doing well what nobody applauds is what builds a company real standing.**

Why these become visible acts

A founder may hear this and say: this is philosophy, how will I know it worked in the business?

The answer is that every one of these turns into a visible act in the corridors of your company. Forbearance is seen in the tone of your voice when the head of operations comes to you with a large order ruined. Compassion is seen in how you answer an employee with a crushing family problem in a pressured week. Humility is seen in admitting a mistake in front of the team without manoeuvring to protect your standing as CEO. Straight dealing is seen in a contract you sign knowing you could twist the other side's arm legally, and refusing to.

Which is why the measure of progress in this book is never a description of a feeling. **It is always a concrete act, seen in an ordinary day.**

THE ACTION

Go back to the one you chose from the twenty two, and bring out one executive opposite for it, on the condition above: an act you do with your decisions or your tongue, not a feeling you wait for.

DOSE

THE ACT

Full

Do the counter act three times this week, and hang it on something fixed in the company: the first meeting with the team, or the writing of the weekly update

Half

Do it once this week

Smallest

Write the counter act in one clear line, in the form of a management decision and not in the form of a good intention

The sign that you moved: you do it once while your pride is hurting and everything in you is fighting you, and afterwards you notice the load that was choking you has begun to lift. **The time you do it while you cannot stand doing it is the one that clears the mirror and widens the life.**

03

PART THREE

The four circles

Yourself, your home, your team, your investors. The circle widens from the centre.

-
- 09 Yourself
 - 10 Your home
 - 11 Your team, the power under your hand
 - 12 Your investors and your board, the power above you

Youself

In two lines

The first circle, and your team, your board and your home all stand on it. **One thing is wanted from it: a rhythm that keeps standing without enthusiasm.**

Not that you become a founder who overflows with energy every morning. That the basics stay standing in the week when the runway is short, the numbers are bad, and you cannot bear to look at your own product.

Why you start here

Because you walk into the board meeting, into the customer negotiation, and through your own front door carrying what is in your body and your nerves, not what you intended for them.

A founder on four broken hours of sleep and cheap caffeine walks into the meeting that decides the next two years of his company in the weakest state his mind has been in all month. He agrees to a term he knows is bad, because agreeing ends the meeting faster than arguing does. Or he goes off in his cofounder's face over a detail that does not matter, and takes six years of trust down in ninety seconds. **The prob-**

lem was not his intelligence. He walked into a fight with a battery at five per cent.

One line, said plainly:

You are selling your health and your time every day for a worthless price, and thinking you are ahead.

You sell them every night in a transaction you count as a gain: the reply at two in the morning to a Slack message that was not urgent, the scroll to see who closed a round nobody will remember next year. **You are selling the only capital nobody can wire you, and buying noise with it.**

The fault in most founders

It is not that you do not want your life in order. **You want in one night what needs a year to build.**

A founder watches something on a Sunday and by midnight he has taken five decisions at once: up at five, five kilometres, fifty pages, no laptop after dark, a hard diet from tomorrow. Tuesday morning a server goes down, or the largest customer threatens to walk, and all five are in the air.

So he decides he is the problem, drops the whole circle, and ends up sleeping worse than before he started.

The cure is not to press harder on yourself. It is to lower what you ask of yourself until it is too small to fall over.

One rule for this circle

One very small act in your body or your time, hung on something fixed, kept standing for thirteen weeks. One quarter. You think in quarters already.

Do not hang it on an alarm: it goes off in the middle of a call, you press snooze, and by evening it never happened. Hang it on something physical that happens anyway: the door closing behind you in the morning, sitting down at the desk before the laptop opens, parking the car outside the house at night.

And the first sixty minutes of the day belong to you. The founder whose hand finds the phone in bed starts the day in reactive mode: his mind becomes a reply to other people's problems before he has had one thought of his own. The founder who keeps the screens shut for the first hour walks into the same emergencies with steadier nerves.

And when you fall

You will fall. That is ordinary and it is priced in.

A server burns. An investor wants a call at seven in the morning. **The rule is that you lower the dose and you do not stop.** The twenty minute walk becomes two minutes round the block. The ten

quiet minutes become one. Because what you are building is not the twenty minutes. **What you are building is that the thread does not snap.**

A month held and three days lost is not a return to the start. That is a story your mind writes to make surrender reasonable.

What it costs to skip this circle

Every founder who reads this decides the outer circles are more urgent: the team is waiting, the board is waiting.

So you work the outer circles out of a body that is failing, and the state you worked in undoes the work: the good hire you interview badly, the update you write in a panic, the ten minutes with your daughter that you spend somewhere else. **This is not the small circle you skip. It is the one that pays for the other three.**

THE ACTION FOR THIS CIRCLE

DOSE

THE ACT

Full

Keep the first forty five minutes after you wake completely free of screens: no phone, no laptop, no television. Eat, and start the day, without one notification

Half

Fifteen minutes of the morning with no screen

Smallest

When you wake, leave the phone on the charger, wash your face and drink a glass of water before you touch a screen

The sign that you moved: a very bad week passes over the company, sales are down, and you do the small act in the middle of the storm anyway. **The week you do it with no appetite and no enthusiasm at all is the only week that measures anything.**

Your home

In two lines

The second circle, and what is wanted from it is **presence, not attendance**. You can leave the office early and sit in your living room for four hours, and the question is not how long you sat but how much of you was left after the team drained you and the investors took the rest.

And a founder who gave up his home for his company loses both.

The ghost in house clothes

This is the commonest thing in founders' homes now, and it did not exist a generation ago.

You get in wrecked, change your clothes and sit down. The laptop is open on your knees and your head is still running burn rate, or drafting a reply to the investor email that came at four.

Your partner tells you about their day and you nod and put the right words in the right gaps: fine, good, it will sort itself out. You did not hear three words in a row. Your son runs in with a drawing and you

look at him over the screen: well done, let me answer this and I am with you. And you do not come.

Then you put your head on the pillow having given four hours to your home. **If they were asked whether you were with them today, they would hesitate and say his body was here.**

The strange part is that this tires you more than presence would: you paid the time and got no rest, they paid patience and got no company. **You have become a ghost carrying his company's problems around his own flat.**

It runs the same way for a founder who is a mother. She gets home to a second shift that starts before her coat is off: homework, a supplier still waiting, dinner. She gives the house four hours too, and not a quarter of her is in them.

The lie about their future

Here is the lie every founder tells himself when guilt arrives: I am destroying myself so the house is safe, so my children never need anything, so that when the exit comes I can make it up to them.

It does not survive one honest look. **Your children at this age do not need a bank account. They need a parent who listens and looks them in the eye.** Your partner needs you present more than a bigger flat.

And you are not doing it only for them. You are doing it to prove something, and because your ego will not sit still next to a competitor

who looks bigger. **Do not dress your own appetite in the clothes of sacrifice and then send your family the bill.**

Ten present minutes

The rule at home is not quantity. Your time is compressed and the weight on you is real.

Ten fully present minutes weigh more than four absent hours. That is a relief, because the long hours are not yours to give and the ten minutes are.

And the trace shows in one thing: **they start telling you small things.** Large problems get told to anybody, because they need solving. The small human detail only gets told to someone who is actually listening.

The weaker side of the table

At home the truest part of a founder shows, because at home are the people under your hand, the ones who cannot squeeze you back the way an investor can.

Each of us is responsible for whoever is under his hand, and responsibility is not spending alone.

Responsibility is that your presence in the house is shelter, not a tension everybody is waiting out.

And the most dangerous thing a founder does under pressure is empty the fear downwards. Two dry sentences from an investor, a customer who refused to pay, and you come home unable to bear a word. Your son knocks over a glass of water and you go off. Not over the glass. **Over the terror locked in your chest all afternoon that could not be let out in front of the man who caused it.**

Smooth in front of the strong and savage in front of the weak. The smoothness was never character.

What ruins the house is small

Not the large quarrel: that happens once and gets dealt with.

What ruins it is the small daily dust: the flat reply when you come in tired, the promise to your son each weekend, then the urgent call with Canada, the laptop open on the dinner table, and the distance widening between you and your partner until three years have gone and you are two strangers in one flat with nothing left to say.

What it costs to skip inwards

A founder reads this and decides to fix the house tonight. He puts the phone in another room, sits down, and is still not in the room.

Because the first circle was skipped. **Presence is not a decision you take at the door. It is what is left of you when you get there.** Four hours of sleep and no unspent hour in six weeks leaves you nothing to

be present with, and you will read the silence as a failure of love when it was a failure of sleep.

THE ACTION FOR THIS CIRCLE

DOSE	THE ACT
Full	The moment you get in, put the phone and the laptop in another room, and sit with them for fifteen full minutes at a hundred per cent: eyes on them, listening only, fixing nothing and advising nothing, until they have finished
Half	Five minutes on the same conditions, phone in another room
Smallest	Ask one question, how was your day, and stay quiet with no screen until the answer is completely finished

The sign that you moved: after two weeks they start the talking before you ask, and the air in the house stops tightening when they hear your key in the door. **That is the house going back to being shelter, not a hotel you escape from in the morning.**

Your team, the power under your hand

In two lines

The third circle, and two things are wanted from it: **an authority that is merciful and does not use people up, and a leader who absorbs the shock instead of passing it on.**

The most dangerous thing in running a startup is emptying your cash anxiety and your board pressure into the chests of people who cannot answer you back, and calling it a mission.

Your team is something entrusted to you. People sold you hours of their one life to build this with you, and they are owed clarity, fairness, respect, and limits that hold. Hold that first, because what comes next is easy to misread without it.

The company is not a family

The most poisonous sentence in startup culture is the warmest: we are not colleagues, we are a family.

The company is not a family and cannot be one. It is a professional team: clear goals, defined roles, fair pay, honest review. A real family

does not let a son go because his third quarter was weak, and does not lay off half its members to protect the runway.

So when a founder says family, he is doing something else without knowing it. **He is borrowing the language of love to ask for sacrifices no employment could ask for:** fourteen hour days, Slack on holidays, a late salary absorbed in silence, because family stands together in hard times. That is a cheap use of young enthusiasm, and it builds a workplace of standing guilt and one sided sacrifice.

A buffer, not a transmitter

Two kinds of founder when the crisis lands.

The first empties. An investor leans on him, sales fall, four months of cash are left, and he walks into the all hands frightened: if we miss the target this month we close and all of you go home. He thinks he is motivating them. He is freezing them. **A founder frightened for his family's food does not invent anything;** he quietly opens job boards under the desk.

The second absorbs. He knows the job is partly to be a buffer: to take the shocks coming down from the fund and the market and hand his team a clear, stable place to think in. He tells them the real state of things without faking it. **He shares the truth and does not export the panic.**

Capable and trustworthy

The best person you can hire is the one who is both capable and trustworthy, and neither one stands in for the other.

Capable is the craft, the ability to close a decision, and a standard of quality you do not let slip. **The kind, soft founder who cannot hold a careless person to account destroys the company and robs the people who are doing the work.**

Trustworthy is fairness in how bonuses and ESOP get shared, contracts honoured, salaries paid on time, and never carrying an employee's work into a board room as your own. **The brilliant founder who cannot be trusted becomes an operator, and every capable person leaves.**

It is a scale you weigh yourself with before you weigh anyone who works for you.

Small authority exposes you

You sign the raise. You write the review. One sentence from you can flatten a twenty six year old for a fortnight or open his life up.

Authority does not corrupt a man, it exposes him. It lifts from him the need to please, and what the need was covering shows.

The founder who is warm with VCs at a conference and then curt with the support agent in his own office does not have a temper problem. **He has a scale that prices people by what they can do for him,** and the conference version was the performance.

The real measure is the tone of your voice with the person who cannot answer you back.

What it costs to skip inwards

A founder tries to fix this circle from outside: a policy, an offsite, a page of values on the wall.

But what comes out of your mouth at four in the afternoon is decided by your sleep and by what happened in your house last night, not by the page. **The founder who skipped the first two circles is not a good leader with a temper problem. He is a tired, frightened man with power over twenty people.**

Clear limits and quiet fairness

Two practical acts repair most of this circle.

A limit you announce and keep: no work messages after seven, no obligation to answer on a holiday. And the half that matters more: you obey it first, so nothing lands in their phones at eleven at night marked no rush.

And fairness where nobody sees it: the bonus for the one who worked in silence, the raise for the one who does not know how to ask,

done without a post about it. **Doing well what nobody sees is yours alone, and it builds something in the company that money cannot buy.**

THE ACTION FOR THIS CIRCLE	
DOSE	THE ACT
Full	Announce a clear daily cut off for Slack and work messages and keep it yourself for a full week, and do one real act of recognition for someone who works hard and does not know how to ask for what he is owed
Half	The limit alone: send no work message to the team today after an hour you set tonight
Smallest	Write one specific, honest thank you to one person for a piece of work this week, and send it privately and not in a channel
The sign that you moved: someone makes a real mistake and comes to your desk to tell you before you find it. He knows he will not be humiliated, and that the man in front of him helps him repair it rather than waiting for a chance to punish.	

Your investors and your board, the power above you

In two lines

The fourth circle and the last, holding two poles that decide your commercial fate and most of your peace: **the power above you**, the investor and the board, **and your peers**, the few founders who actually know you.

Two things are wanted: to turn the investor relationship from a frightened performance into a grown up partnership, and the startup scene from networking into company that holds you when you stumble.

If you have no investor

The power above you is still there. It is the bank holding your loan, the supplier who sets your terms, or the one customer who is half your revenue. Read investor as whoever can change your month without asking you, and this chapter runs for you in the same order.

Not a god and not an enemy

Founders fall into one of two traps, and both strangle the company.

The first is the cash god. The founder who sees the investor as holding life and death over his company. The fund's name lights up his phone and his chest drops. A casual opinion from a man who has never read the product code or sat with a customer becomes an order for the quarter. The roadmap turns every three months to suit a taste, he loses standing with his own team, and becomes a frightened employee administering someone else's money. **A man who hangs his survival on one person's approval is in the narrowest prison there is.**

The second is the enemy at the gate. The founder who takes the money and then treats the investor as an occupier come for his work. Passive aggression in meetings, real numbers withheld, problems mentioned only when the company is already going under. That is a betrayal of a trust, and short sighted: it throws away the one thing the investor was good for, a network and experience in getting companies out of holes.

The right weight is simpler than both. The investor is a commercial partner in a risk: he came in with money and experience, you with your years, your mind and your team. He was trusted with other people's money, so of course he asks and wants to understand, and you are owed respect for your craft as long as you are honest.

The monthly update as theatre

The most exhausting thing in a founder's nervous life is the permanent performance.

The monthly investor update becomes an exercise in cosmetics: you pick the charts that are green, you inflate the vanity metric, new signups, to cover the fall in real sales, and the disaster goes on the last page in small type, soft enough to hide it.

The intelligent investor smells the makeup from a distance and quietly stops trusting you. And you live in dread of the day the truth surfaces on its own.

The cure is transparency that is uncomfortable to write. Professional investors hate surprises and respect the founder who writes plainly: here are the good numbers, here is what went wrong last week and what it cost, here is the plan for the next thirty days, here is where we need you.

That email lands on your own chest like cold water. It lifts the performance off you and puts the investor next to you as a partner, not behind you as an inspector.

Contacts in the thousands

Open your phone, or LinkedIn. Thousands of relationships, from every accelerator, conference and demo day.

Then ask the question that hurts. **Which of those thousands could you ring at eleven at night and say: I cannot make payroll this month, I am frightened, I do not know what to do?**

Most founders arrive at zero.

That is the narrowing exactly: contacts in the thousands and complete isolation. A scene built on who can introduce me to a VC narrows a life rather than widening it: every sitting has a purpose in it and a performance on top, and nobody dares show weakness in case it prices his company down by Monday.

The companion who counts is the one you come away from calmer, steadier and nearer the truth.

Not the man handing out cards. You do not need a large network. **You need one or two founder peers who are genuinely safe:** not competing with you, settled enough that your bad quarter is not entertainment, people you can tell a weakness to and hear an honest sentence back without it reaching the market by Tuesday.

The trade scale does not fit here

For a mind that runs on numbers all day, the mistake is to price people the same way: what do I get out of this coffee, what does this man open up for me.

People are not resources to be managed, and friendship is not built anywhere except in sittings with no purpose and no laptop.

The founder who turns every relationship into a deal ends up alone in a palace of business cards worth nothing on the night it hurts.

What it costs to skip inwards

This is the outermost circle, the first to show when the inner three are empty.

A founder who is honest with his board and lying to himself about his sleep will not hold it for two quarters. A founder with a peer to call at eleven at night and a partner he has not looked at in two months has built the widest ring on nothing. **The calm you sit with in a board seat is bought at six hours a night and a house that is not on fire.**

THE ACTION FOR THIS CIRCLE

DOSE

THE ACT

Full

Write the next investor update with no makeup: one real challenge and one real loss, stated plainly. And ask one founder friend for a coffee this week with no agenda in it

Half

A ten minute call to a founder friend about his health and his family only, with no mention of funding or the market

Smallest

Send one honest, specific thank you to an investor for a decent thing he did or a piece of advice that helped, and ask for nothing else in the same message

The sign that you moved: an investor answers your honest report by thanking you for the clarity and asking how he can help. Or a founder friend rings you out of nowhere and tells you about his own failure, **because you opened a door he could not find at any conference.**

04

PART FOUR

How to walk

The day, the week, what you do when you stop, and how you leave.

-
- 13 The day: one act in three doses
 - 14 The week: five, one, and open
 - 15 When you stop: a down round, a pivot, a co-founder crisis
 - 16 The way out: the real exit

The day: one act in three doses

In two lines

This is the first skill in the book, and if you came out of the whole thing with nothing else you would have taken most of it.

That you can write yourself an act that survives a real day in a real company. What falls out of a founder's plans does not fall because something is missing in you. It falls because it was written in a shape that no week with a fire in it could carry.

Your day is three steps

In a company, complexity is the first enemy. The more detail your plan for the day has in it, the sooner it goes down: at the first outage, the first customer who threatens to leave, the first investor email that lands at eleven at night.

So the day is three steps, and there is no fourth.

Where you are. One minute, a flat look at the cash, the company and your own nerves today. A description, not a trial.

What you do. One act in the core of the business, the one brick that has to go in today.

How you know you moved. A sign you can see with your own eyes before the laptop closes.

How an act that can be done gets written

Four conditions. Whichever one is missing brings the whole thing down inside a week.

The first: small enough to make you laugh. If you look at the line and think, this is too small to be an objective, this is not what bends the growth curve, then you have the size right to the millimetre. People resist the enormous thing that lands on them all at once, and freeze in front of it. Nobody resists the act they think nothing of.

The second: hung on an event, not on an hour. "After standup" is worth a hundred of "at ten". Ten o'clock passes over you while you are inside a call or inside a server problem, and you never feel it go. The event happens in front of you, so you remember.

Watch how the day actually goes. You set the act for four in the afternoon. At four you are in a room with a candidate, or on the phone with the bank, or reading a resignation you did not expect. Six o'clock comes and the act was never refused, it was simply never met. **Hang it on standup and it meets you every morning, whether the day is calm or on fire.** Take the event from your company's real day, not

from the day you wish you were running: after standup, when the last call ends, when the laptop closes.

The third: it has a sign you can touch. "Improve sales" is not a sign. "Be a calmer leader with the team" is a wish. A sign answers yes or no: one call to one customer who is hesitating, one support ticket closed, the cash number sent to your co-founder.

The fourth: it takes shrinking. This is the finest of the four and the one most founder plans die on.

Shrinking by reducing, not by substituting

Every act you set yourself has three doses: **full, half, and smallest.** And the smallest is not a different, easier act. **It is the same act, smaller.**

THE ACT	CORRECT SHRINKING	WRONG SHRINKING
Reach out to prospects	Send one message to one customer	Read an article on persuasion
Fix a bug in the product	Fix one line, or write the ticket properly	Hold a team brainstorm about tech debt
Sit with my son after work	Two minutes with him, fully present, no phone	Buy him something online while working
Watch the cash	Open the bank account, look at the number, close it	Turn the runway over in your head for two hours

Look at the difference. The founder who sent one message is selling, and tomorrow he can send five. The founder who read about selling

has changed the road and gone off into theory, and tomorrow he will sell nothing. **The point is not the effort you saved, the point is that the road stays one road.**

Two buttons, not three

At the end of the day, when you close the laptop, you have two answers. **Done, and smaller.**

There is no third button called did not do, and there is no column in your sheet called failed. If the act did not happen, that is not news about you and it is not news about your appetite for any of this. **It is technical, neutral news: the dose was bigger than your day and bigger than what the company was carrying today.** So tomorrow you step down one, to the half or to the smallest, and the wheel keeps turning.

And do not hold yourself to account for one day. A day is too small a unit to judge a company by, and far too small to judge yourself by. The reckoning is for the week, and the week is the next chapter.

THE ACTION

DOSE

THE ACT

Full

Write one act in the core of your work or your health, hung on a fixed daily event, with its three doses and its sign, in four clear lines

Half

Write the act and the event it hangs on, and nothing else

Smallest

Write the event on its own: one thing that happens in your company every day without exception, after standup, or when the laptop closes

The sign that you moved: you find yourself doing the small act the moment the event happens, without opening a ticket and without looking at a note. It has stopped being an intention you think about and become part of the day.

The week: five, one, and open

In two lines

A day on its own is too small and too moody to steer a company by, and a roadmap year is too large to hold. **The week is the unit a founder is actually measured in.** This chapter gives you its shape: five working days on one act, one strategic half hour, and one open day with no business in it.

Why the week in particular

Because it is longer than your mood and shorter than the damage.

A founder who reckons by the day wrongs himself and wrongs the company. One Tuesday where a deal dies and the servers fall over, and by ten at night he has sentenced the company. **A founder who reckons by the quarter forgets.** Three months go by with whole weeks in them nobody can account for.

The week is wide enough for something to break on Tuesday, for you to be on your feet on Wednesday, and to close on Thursday with one real brick in the wall.

The five days

Five working days in which the one act you chose runs, at whatever dose the day can carry. Energy high and the team steady: the full dose. A day of emergencies and investor calls: the half, or the smallest.

And the condition that holds the shape up: do not change the act in the middle of the week. Not when you are bored of it, not when a thread at midnight puts a new trend in front of you. Change the dose, not the act. Swapping the goal every three days is what produces the scatter you are trying to get out of.

The strategic half hour

One half hour near the end of the week with no execution in it. No customer messages, no dashboards, no tickets. You sit with yourself, and with your co-founder if you have one, and put one large question on the table.

Are we building this because a customer needs it and will pay, or because we like building it? What drained the most cash this week, and did it return anything? Who on the team needs a thank you tomorrow?

Its use is that it brakes the machine, so the work does not turn into blind motion. A founder who runs two months straight without asking one strategic question is working because he started, not because he knows where he is going.

The open day

One full day with nothing professional asked of it: no act, no question, no making up what slipped, no Slack, no glancing at the sales numbers.

And this is your day off, not your company's shutdown. The shop opens, the line runs, the team works. You are the one stepping out.

This is the hardest part of the shape on a founder, because the culture you grew up inside taught you one illness: the fear of being away. Every app on your phone measures an unbroken run for you and tells you that if you are gone for a day the company dies.

If your company cannot stand twenty four hours without you touching it, you do not have a company yet, you have a job you have locked yourself inside.

And that measure is for a founder with a team he can delegate to. Not for someone working alone, not for someone in his sixth month, and not for work where you are the service being sold.

By rule, not by mood

And this is what separates a real open day from one you wish for every week and never get:

A rule you set once is stronger than a decision you take every week, because the decision is the thing that fails.

A founder waiting each week to see whether he can afford to stop never stops: he enters the same fight four times a month and loses. A founder who made the day a rule and told his people it is closed is not negotiating at all.

And a founder who leaves the company for a day because he decided to keeps his mind in the company. He looks once, answers one message, tells himself this is not work, this is just clearing. A founder who leaves because the rule says so actually comes out, because he has nothing to bargain with.

Every people that lasted kept a day it stops on by rule. We are the first to take it out and go looking for a substitute in an app.

Closed, then open

The day is two halves. **Its first half is closed:** the laptop is shut, the messages stay shut, nothing from the week is made up. **Its second half is opened:** you spread out into something else. Your family, a long meal, a drive, people who have never said the word runaway. Or nothing, but nothing by your own choice.

That is why it is called the open day and not the empty day. The empty day sits on your chest and hands you back to the screen inside two hours. The open day makes room for you.

And the day itself is a variable. In Cairo and Riyadh the week runs Sunday to Thursday, the half hour falls late on Thursday and the open day is Friday. Whoever's customers take that day chooses another: the shape is one, the name changes. What matters is that it has a name, that one person knows it, and that it does not move every week.

The week sheet

All of it gathers on one sheet you fill in by hand every week: **which circle you are in · the act and its three doses · the event it hangs on · the sign · your strategic question · your open day · and seven boxes, one a day.**

The boxes are a counter, not a chain. What has passed is not cancelled because one breaks, and there is no box for failure.

THE ACTION

DOSE

THE ACT

Full

Fill in the week sheet for your company, name your open day, and hold it this week: no Slack and no laptop for twenty four hours

Half

Fill in two lines only: the act you will hold for five days, and your strategic question

Smallest

Name your open day and nothing more, and tell your co-founder or your team you are not available in it except for a real fire

The sign that you moved: the open day passes with the laptop shut. The first time, the first two hours will feel like guilt. By the third week the day passes with your people and there is nothing in your chest.

When you stop: a down- round, a pivot, a co- founder crisis

In two lines

You will stop. That is not pessimism and not a possibility, it is news. **This book was not built for the founder whose line goes up smooth and straight in a post, it was built for the one who hits a wall, sits in the dark for a night, and gets up again.** This chapter gives you what to do on that particular night.

The night the wall goes up

A week comes when the road is simply blocked.

The round you spent six months preparing falls apart in the last meeting, and the lead comes back asking for a valuation under the last one, on terms that cost you your pride. Or you find, two years in, that the market moved and nobody will pay for the old product, and there is no way through except a pivot that pulls down half of what you

built. Or the co-founder you started with is in a different place on the vision or the cap table, and the two of you are at a dead end.

That night you turn off the lights, sit at your desk with your breath tight, and hear the voice: it is finished, you have been found out.

The first thing to know at that hour: **stopping is not a defect in you and it is not the end of the world.** Every large company you can name went through that same night: the messaging tool that began as a game nobody played, the pair selling cereal boxes to make rent. **The difference between the ones who crossed and the ones who ended is not the size of the crisis, it is what they did on the night they stopped.**

A shock or a cold spell

These are two different things, and most founders treat each with the other's medicine.

A shock is a sudden hit: a cold email from the board, a cheque that bounced, a contract cancelled. Its treatment is silence for twenty four hours. No strategic decision, no message to anyone, until it is out of your blood.

A cold spell is two months of waking up and dragging yourself into the same work with no life in it. Nothing visible happened. The numbers stand where they are, the operation runs, customers are served, and the appetite is out.

One question separates them. **Is it the act that stopped, or the leaning?** If the act still stands and only the enthusiasm has gone cold, that is a cold spell. It is not a verdict and not a punishment. It arrives after the unreasonable effort of the early years, and it has come to people better than us.

The cure is a smaller dose

This is the most important line in the chapter.

When the wall goes up, the first reckless move is to throw the lot in the air: close the laptop, disappear from the company, tell everyone to leave you alone. **That is what turns a stumble into a permanent collapse.**

Come down instead to the smallest operating dose you have. If you were pushing five features, stop four and keep the one that serves your most important customer. If you were working twelve hours, work four, on the essentials nobody else can carry. Serve the customers you already have, protect the cash, and let the rest pass.

What matters is that you keep moving, even by an ant step a day. **The appetite follows the act, not the other way round.** A founder who keeps moving lightly with no enthusiasm finds it back within days. A founder waiting in bed for it to return by itself is waiting for something that does not come back by waiting.

And the smallest real thing you do in the week of a crisis is worth more to the company than the finest plan you turn over

while paralysed. There is no column in any of this for flogging yourself: there was none in the day, and there is none here.

What broke does not undo what was built

The most dangerous thing about that night is not the crisis. It is the sentence you believe at two in the morning: **two years went into the ground and we are back at zero.**

That is not true. You are not carrying two years in the number in the bank. You are carrying experience that went into your bones, and code that still runs, and real relationships with customers and suppliers, and a steadiness that makes you far more sober than the founder who opened the company on day one. **That is live capital, and nothing on earth wipes it.**

And take one picture with you. A founder kept a build log, one line a day, for a month. Then a bad board call came and he was away a week. He came back, opened the file, looked at the date on the last line, and deleted all of it.

Nobody deleted it for him. The week away took not one line from him. What took the whole month were the three seconds after the week.

So breaking off is not undoing. The undoing is pulling down what you built, with your own hand, after the stumble.

Coming back is a door that does not shut

If you have to go back to an investor you turned down, or back to a customer you lost, or to apologise to your co-founder, go back with your head up. Coming back to save the company and correct the road is not weakness. **It is the most grown up thing a founder does.** As long as there is breath in your chest and your mind works, there is not one line here telling you that you are later than you are allowed to be.

THE ACTION

This chapter is read now and used on the night you hit the wall. Put a mark on it, and when the night comes, the restart is the smallest dose you have, not a new plan.

DOSE

THE ACT

Full

On the night you stop: come down to your smallest operating dose, serve the customers you have and protect the cash, and stay there seven days with no new strategic decision and no reckoning with yourself

Half

Do that smallest operating dose once, on one day of the week you stopped in

Smallest

Open the laptop for one minute, look at the bank number calmly, close it, and take no decision tonight

The sign that you moved: you are back on your feet and correcting the road on the third day, not six months later. **The difference between the founder who comes back after three days and the one who comes back after a year is not will, it is that he knew coming back was allowed.**

The way out: the real exit

In two lines

In the language of startups, exit has one meaning: an acquisition, or a listing, and a number landing in an account. **This chapter is about a different exit, the one that decides how a founder actually lives.** And its job is to graduate you, because a book you need in a year the way you need it today is a failed book, however fond of it you are.

The exit everyone means

A founder can compress his whole life, his youth and his health, into one day: the day a large company buys the thing, or the day the shares open on an exchange. He is certain the cheque will erase the tension and fill the space in his chest.

Then listen to founders who did it at real size. The morning after the celebration, with the money in the account, they woke into something heavier than anything they felt while building.

Why? **Because the money widened the account and left the man exactly where he was.** He finds out that morning that he built an idol

and spent years serving it, and that when he sold it he did not know who he was without the title and the dashboard.

The exit this book was written for is your exit from the company as an idol. You build it, grow it, compete, win cleanly and negotiate hard, and stay free on the inside: your worth as a person is not waiting on a stamp from a fund or a valuation number in a news story.

What you take in your pocket

Not the book. Pages are pages and they do nothing on their own. **You take three tools**, and they serve you here and in anything you build after.

The first: you know where you are standing. Six layers under you, and you start at layer zero, your sleep and your body, before you go near strategy. Four circles, yourself, your home, your team, your investors, and width that starts at the centre and moves out. And you can tell a market storm that passes from a fear that has moved in and lives with you.

The second: you can write an act that can be done. One act, hung on a real event, with three doses and a sign you can touch. **That is the skill that saves you from paralysis in the hardest weeks of a business**, and it works far outside these pages.

The third: you know what to do on the night you stop. Down to the smallest operating dose, no belief in the lie that you are back at zero, on your feet again on the third day. That is the dearest of the

three, because everyone who ever dropped something dropped it in the moment he stopped and did not know what to do.

How you know you have left

By one sign. **You run your week and write your act without opening these pages.** Two weeks pass, then three, with ordinary pressure in them and sales moving up and down, and you are steady: your home has its share, your team is safe under you, and your investor hears the truth from you calmly.

When that happens, put the book in a drawer. **And do not think you gave something up; that was what was asked of you.**

And do not credit us with it

This is the last advice here, and the truest.

If the company came through and your life widened, this book is not the cause of it, and nobody here has a claim on you. **What did it is that you got up night after night and did one small thing while something in you argued and was afraid.**

And none of it came from you alone either. **The people around you and the circumstances that came were part of it:** someone made something easier for you without being asked, and a day came light when it could as easily have come heavy.

A founder who credits a book, or a course, or a mentor, or a fund has hung the width of his life on something outside himself, so when it

is absent his chest narrows again and he does not know why. **And attachment is one of the twenty two, so do not walk out of here carrying one.**

And one last thing

You will not become a different person, and you will not be a unicorn in thirty days. **You will be yourself, with your ordinary weakness and your ambition and your company, in a wider space.** That is what the first page promised you, and it promised nothing else.

So if life narrows around you in a year, open the week sheet, write one small act with its three doses, and hang it on something that happens in your day.

THE ACTION

DOSE

THE ACT

Full

Put this book on the shelf and run next week off a blank sheet: the act, its three doses, its event and its sign, written without opening a page here

Half

Write the three tools in your own words, one line each

Smallest

Answer one question in one sentence: who are you when the company's name is taken off you?

The sign that you moved: a week goes by with real pressure in it, an investor pushing and the numbers flat, and you run it from the sheet in your own hand. **At the end of it you notice you did not need to open this once.**

Last page and the founder's week sheet

One line at the end of the road

Everything in this book comes back to one sentence, and you can carry it out of here without the rest of the pages: **the operating structure stays fixed, and one thing inside it changes.**

One sheet, filled in fifty two times a year. One executive act in the week, not two. Three doses of that act, clear, and no more than three.

That is smaller than what you came looking for. It is meant to be.

What breaks a founder is not that he does not know what to do on Monday. It is that he decides it again, from nothing, every Monday. A new plan after a hard board call. A new priority after a red dashboard. A new operating system for his whole life on the night the runway drops under nine months. A founder who redesigns his week every week does not have a week. He has fifty two first attempts, and not one of them ran long enough to tell him anything true.

Fixedness is what makes the thing survivable. Not because the shape is clever, but because you already know it by heart. You are not inventing anything on a Sunday morning with a cash gap in front of you and

two people waiting on your answer. **You are filling in a form you have filled in forty times, in the same order, with your hand moving before your head is fully awake.** The decision was taken once, months ago, in a calm hour, and the bad week does not get a vote on it.

And it is one act and not two, because two is how you end with none. Two acts means a choice every morning about which one gets you today, and a choice every morning is an argument every morning, and you have enough of those before ten. **One act ends the argument before it starts.**

The three doses are the release valve. The week a large customer churns and your best engineer resigns on the same afternoon is not the week you drop the act. It is the week you take the smallest version of it, the ant step, and write the word in the box. **What survives a bad week at a tenth of its size is worth more than what ran at full size for three good weeks and then stopped.**

And the seven boxes are a counter, not a chain. Nothing you have built is cancelled because one day went badly, **and there is no box in this book for failure, and there never was one.**

The founder's week sheet

Print it, or keep it in one notes file that is yours alone. Fill it on Sunday morning, or at the start of whatever your week is.

FIELD	WHAT YOU WRITE IN IT
Where am I now?	Which of the four circles needs the work this week: myself, my home, my team, or my investors and my people
What am I working on?	One or two words only. One clear thing, not two. B2B sales. Regular sleep. Straight talk with the board
The anchoring event	Something physical that already happens in your company every day without you deciding it: after the morning standup, the first time I sit at my desk, once the laptop is shut
The full dose	The act at its full and comfortable size, for the day that goes your way
The half dose	The same act at half the amount, for the day that fills up on you
The smallest	The smallest possible version of the same act. An ant step that keeps the thread from breaking
The observable sign	How do I know I moved? Something physical, that can be seen and answered yes or no. Anything else is a wish
The Thursday strategic question	One large, honest question you put to yourself and to your co-founder in half a quiet hour before the week closes
The open day	The name of the day you pull the plug on the company and on Slack completely. Friday, for example
The seven day counter	Saturday, Sunday, Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday, Friday. At the end of each day write one of two words: done, or smaller. A running counter, with no box in it for failure and none for beating yourself up

A word on where this comes from

What you have read here is not western theory carried across into another language, and it is not a set of opinions I arrived at on my own and dressed up for you.

It was taken out of old books, read in full and not mined for quotations: **Madarij al Salikin** by Ibn Qayyim, **Ihya Ulum al Din** by al Ghazali, **the aphorisms of Ibn Ata Allah**, and the work of **al Shatibi** and **Ibn Khaldun** on society and human nature. What was pulled out of them are the general laws, how a life widens and how a person becomes still, and those laws were then set back down in the language of what you are actually living: startups, screens, Slack, the particular fear that arrives with a shrinking runway, and funds and investors in 2026.

The terms were changed for a working book, one you run on a Tuesday with a payroll question open in another tab. The sources were not. Where a line here is carrying the weight of an argument, it came from one of those books, and you are owed the name, so you can go back, read it yourself, and disagree with it.

And the last thing to say

You were not promised on the first page of this book that you would be Steve Jobs.

You were not promised that the market would settle, or that investors would stop pushing, or that cash would come down on you

from the sky while you slept. **Building is heavy and it stays heavy,** and nothing in these pages was written to tell you otherwise.

One thing was promised, and only one. **That your life and your chest become wide enough for your company and for the people inside it.** And that on the night the world closes in on you, and one night out of the nights will, you have in your hand a clear structure and a working tool, and you know how to run it yourself, without waiting for anybody to come and start it for you.

And that is enough.



05

THE PRACTICAL PART

The notebook

There is no explanation from here to the end of the book. The explanation is behind you. This is a shape you fill in: one page, fifty two times a year.

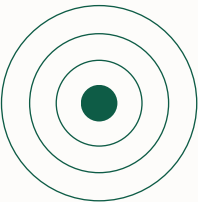
-
- 01 Before you start
 - 02 The week sheet, with its reference numbers
 - 03 Two weeks filled in by hand
 - 04 Ten blank sheets

BEFORE YOU START

There is no explanation in this notebook. The explanation is the book.

One act in the week, not two. Three doses, no more.

A day you do nothing is not a failure. Write smaller, and carry on.



This page is yours alone. Copy it as often as you like, and do not hand it to anyone to fill in for you.

1

Where am I now?

One of the four. Not two.

yourself your home your team your investors

2

What am I working on?

A word or two. One thing, not two.

3

What it hangs on

Something that happens anyway: after standup, when the last call ends, when the shutter goes down, on the drive home.

4

The act, three doses

Small enough that you could say it out loud to your co-founder without flinching.

Full

Half

Smallest

5

The sign

Something you can touch. Otherwise it is talk.

6

Thursday question

One question you ask yourself in a quiet half hour before the week closes.

The open day

The day the company is unplugged. By rule, not by mood.

8

The week

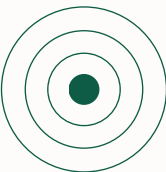
Day by day: done, or smaller. There is no third box.

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
done	done	done	done	done	done	
smaller	smaller	smaller	smaller	smaller	smaller	open
					question	

Omar

35 · Cairo · logistics software, 19 people, seven months of runway

He wakes at half past seven with his hand already on the phone. He opens the dashboard in bed, spends the day putting fires out, and by the evening he cannot say what he built. He said that is the first thing he wants to stop.



Where am I now?

One of the four. Not two.

yourself your home your team your investors

What am I working on?

A word or two. One thing, not two.

The first hour is mine

What it hangs on

Something that happens anyway: after standup, when the last call ends, when the shutter goes down, on the drive home.

When I sit down at my desk, before Slack

The act, three doses

Small enough that you could say it out loud to your co-founder without flinching.

Full One full hour on one thing in the product or the selling, phone face down

Half Half an hour

Smallest Ten minutes on one thing, then stop

The sign

Something you can touch. Otherwise it is talk.

At the end of the day I can say one sentence: today I built this

Thursday question

One question you ask yourself in a quiet half hour before the week closes.

If the company closed next month, would the hour I spent today have mattered?

The open day

The day the company is unplugged. By rule, not by mood.

Sunday

The week

Day by day: done, or smaller. There is no third box.

Mon done smaller	Tue done smaller	Wed done smaller	Thu done smaller	Fri done smaller	Sat done smaller question	Sun open
------------------------	------------------------	------------------------	------------------------	------------------------	------------------------------------	-------------

THE WEEK AS IT HAPPENED

Omar

Mon	<i>Closed Slack and sat an hour on pricing. First time in two months.</i>	done
Tue	<i>Another hour. Came out with something usable.</i>	done
Wed	<i>Server went down in the morning. I was firefighting. Ten minutes, that was it.</i>	smaller
Thu	<i>Drove to a customer. The whole day went.</i>	
Fri	<i>Back to the hour. Hard after a lost day, but I did it.</i>	done
Sat	<i>Sat with the question. The answer bothers me.</i>	question
Sun	<i>Closed the laptop early. Went out.</i>	open

THE SIGN, END OF WEEK

Three days with a real hour in them. Two months ago there were none.

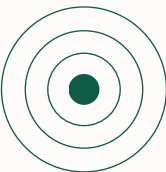
THURSDAY QUESTION

No. I have spent this month on things that would not be missed by anyone.

Nadia

32 · Riyadh · fintech founder, raising a seed round

She sends a monthly investor update, spends two days on it, takes out every ugly number and puts a chart in its place. The last time an investor asked her a simple question she had no answer, so she decided to change the whole thing.



Where am I now?

One of the four. Not two.

yourself your home your team your investors

What am I working on?

A word or two. One thing, not two.

The update tells the truth

What it hangs on

Something that happens anyway: after standup, when the last call ends, when the shutter goes down, on the drive home.

First Tuesday of the month, ten o'clock

The act, three doses

Small enough that you could say it out loud to your co-founder without flinching.

Full *Write the update in twenty minutes, and make the first line my worst number*

Half *Send the worst number in a short message*

Smallest *Write the number down for myself*

The sign

Something you can touch. Otherwise it is talk.

An investor replies with a question about that number, not with thanks

Thursday question

One question you ask yourself in a quiet half hour before the week closes.

Am I dressing the update up for them, or because I cannot look at the number myself?

The open day

The day the company is unplugged. By rule, not by mood.

Sunday

The week

Day by day: done, or smaller. There is no third box.

Mon <u>done</u> smaller	Tue done smaller	Wed done <u>smaller</u> a counter, not a	Thu <u>done</u> smaller chain · and no	Fri done smaller box for failure	Sat done smaller question	Sun open
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THE WEEK AS IT HAPPENED

Nadia

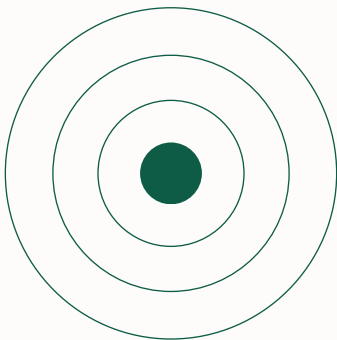
Mon	<i>Wrote the update in thirty minutes. First line: churn at nine per cent.</i>	done
Tue	<i>Flat day. Wrote nothing.</i>	
Wed	<i>Wrote the number in my notes and left it there.</i>	smaller
Thu	<i>Two of them replied asking about churn. One offered an introduction.</i>	done
Fri	<i>Travelling.</i>	
Sat	<i>Half an hour with the question.</i>	question
Sun	<i>Closed everything. Slept early.</i>	open

THE SIGN, END OF WEEK

Two replied with a question about the number. Before this they replied with thanks.

THURSDAY QUESTION

Because of me. Written down it becomes real, and I had been putting off seeing it.



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One of the four. Not two.

yourself your home your team your investors

What am I working on?

A word or two. One thing, not two.

What it hangs on

Something that happens anyway: after standup, when the last call ends, when the shutter goes down, on the drive home.

The act, three doses

Small enough that you could say it out loud to your co-founder without flinching.

Full

Half

Smallest

The sign

Something you can touch. Otherwise it is talk.

Thursday question

One question you ask yourself in a quiet half hour before the week closes.

The open day

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The week

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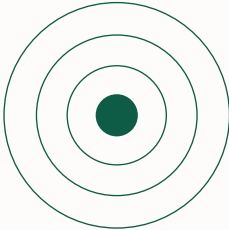
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done	done	done	done	done	done	open
smaller	smaller	smaller	smaller	smaller	smaller	
					question	

Fifty two of these.

One act. Three doses. A day that is open by rule.



A book for a founder who left a job to be free, and found the narrowest cage a person can walk into.

Nothing went wrong. The company is running, customers are paying, and people look at him and say he made it. He is the only one who knows his chest has gone narrow, and that everything he has read never landed on a single day of his week.

Why it got narrow. The map of what you are made of and what the opposite of it is. The four circles: yourself, your home, your team, your investors. And how to walk through a day and a week you can actually repeat.

Every chapter ends with one act in three doses. There is no column here for flogging yourself, and there will not be one.

